Baburnama, ‘then came the Uzbeks, the foreign foe from God knows where, and took over.’ The Uzbeks were a Turki-speaking tribe like Babur’s, but they were ethnically distinct and, under the leadership of Shaibani Khan Uzbek, they harried Mirza* Babur, only twelve years old when he lost his father, first from Samarkand, and then out of Ferghana altogether. ‘Mischief and devastation,’ lamented Babur, ‘must always be expected from the Mughul horde.’ Finally, in 1504, bolstered by his intrepid grandmother, Aisan Daulat Begum, his mother, Qutlugh Nigar Khanum, and ‘300 lightly armed men’ Babur conquered Kabul. For twenty years in this crossroads city filled with a scattershot of languages and traders and merchants from different corners of the world, Babur tried to create a capital that would live up to his Timurid ambitions. He planted gardens, straightened streams, and welcomed exiled Timurid family members from across Timur’s old empire, driven to Kabul by the relentless rise of Shaibani Khan Uzbek. All this Babur would accomplish with his tightly knit warband, described by historian Jos Gommans:

> Like many Chinggisid khans or Timurid mirzas, Babur had a warband of his own, consisting of both relatives and retainers, who were linked to each other through marriage and companionship. The latter was sustained in recurrent social events ranging from hunts to drugs-and-drinking bouts.

Babur would always celebrate and revere his Timurid identity over his Chingizid one for his loathed foes, the Uzbeks, also claimed Chingizid blood. It would therefore be all the more galling for Babur’s descendants that they would be called by the Persian word for Mongol—Mughal. After several unsuccessful attempts to reclaim Samarkand, Babur realized that he would have to abandon his homeland forever and, instead, decided to look eastwards. Bolstered by the new title of Padshah,* Babur conducted five raids on Hindustan during his years in Kabul. His campaigns were based on the fragile claim that, since Timur had conquered Delhi in an earlier age, the city was legitimately his. Finally, in 1525, Babur sent a goshawk to the Afghan Lodi ruler in Delhi, Ibrahim Lodi, with the request that he hand over Delhi to Babur for ‘the country which from old had depended on the Turk’. Ibrahim Lodi refused. So, at the age of forty-two, accompanied by his thirteen-year-old son, Humayun, Babur marched on Delhi with 8,000 Timurid and Pashtun warriors.